



Gearing up for action: India and Pakistan will face each other at the 34,000-seater Nassau County International Cricket Stadium in the 2024 T20 World Cup. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

international cricket or get an IPL contract,” Sait said.

One drawback, as Sait points out, is a lack of government support. This will happen only when local Americans take a liking to the sport.

This was true in the UAE as well, when Emirati Sultan Zarawani led the national team in the 1990s. “When Sultan was playing, there was substantial official support for cricket in the UAE. Once he stopped playing, official funding and support stopped,” Sait said.

Hosting the World Cup could provide the spark to get the government on board in the USA. “The 1987 World Cup hosted in India gave the sport a huge boost here. A similar spurt can occur if the T20 World Cup is a success in the USA,” Sait said. On a professional level,

there are now more opportunities to move to the USA and take up cricket as a career option. Take the case of Sindhu Ashok, an India ‘A’ woman cricketer, who got married and moved to the USA to take up a corporate job. She started playing club cricket and now leads the USA’s national women’s team. A.S. Sri Krishna followed a similar path, shifting base to the USA to play for Minor League Cricket side San Diego Surf Riders. Krishna, who played in the Karnataka State Cricket Association Division I league and represented the Indian indoor cricket team, noted that grounds in the USA may not be on par with those in India.

When USA Cricket’s application to join the ICC was approved in 2019, cricket administration got better

streamlined. This paved the way for the advent of Minor League Cricket, a development T20 league for Major League Cricket. Krishna was among the players roped in when Minor League Cricket teams looked for quality talent. “A lot of players were signed from India, Sri Lanka, and Pakistan,” Krishna said.

The administrative cricket body of the USA has had its fair share of trouble, having been suspended by the ICC for long periods. With an official, recognised system now in place, the picture looks a lot more palatable. “Hosting the World Cup is a step in the right direction. The USA will also host the Olympics in 2028, which will feature cricket as a discipline. This brings a lot of hope for the development of cricket in the region,” Krishna said.